Around this time Moshe Dayan, the storied Israeli general, made his way to Mount Scopus, which offers a commanding view of the city. He leaned over to Col Uzi Narkis, the head of the army's central command, and whispered a single question: "What do we need all this Vatican for?"

The city of peace

The holy city, the city of God, the city—all too ironically—of peace. Of the many names for Jerusalem, though, none is repeated so often as "our undivided, eternal capital". It's not only a right-wing slogan: Yair Lapid, the great centrist hope of Israel's Ashkenazi middle class, vows in one breath to solve the conflict with the Palestinians, and in the next to keep Jerusalem united forever. Isaac Herzog promised the same before the 2015 election.

The United Nations, the United States, the European Union, and much of the rest of the world consider East Jerusalem to be occupied territory. Israel insists that it is not. A casual visitor might be inclined to agree. Crossing Route 60, the four-lane boulevard that roughly follows the armistice line, hardly feels like traversing a border. In Sheikh Jarrah, a neighborhood adjacent to the Old City, the east side of the highway is lined with luxury hotels. Many of the tourists who stay there are unaware that their rooms are meant to be part of a future Palestinian state.

If you drive a bit further into East Jerusalem, though, the difference quickly becomes apparent. Silwan is built in a ravine. At the top, the neighborhood abuts the Zion Gate into the Old City, where tour buses queue up throughout the day. At the bottom, the roads are barely paved, and rubbish piles up in vacant lots; municipal services are spotty, to say the least.

Only a handful of the 300,000 Palestinians in East Jerusalem are Israeli citizens. They, or their ancestors, chose to keep their Jordanian nationality after 1967. So Israel treats them as "permanent residents": they hold the same blue ID cards as Israeli citizens, which allow them to work and travel freely throughout the country; but they cannot vote in national elections, nor can they apply for Israeli passports. Their status is tenuous, and can be revoked if they move abroad or otherwise lose their "center of life" in the city.

They can also apply for citizenship, though the annual number of requests used to be in the dozens. Lately it has grown more than tenfold: in